Why do transfers fail?

Usage, playing time and luck after a move, Big-5, 2014–15 to 2024–25

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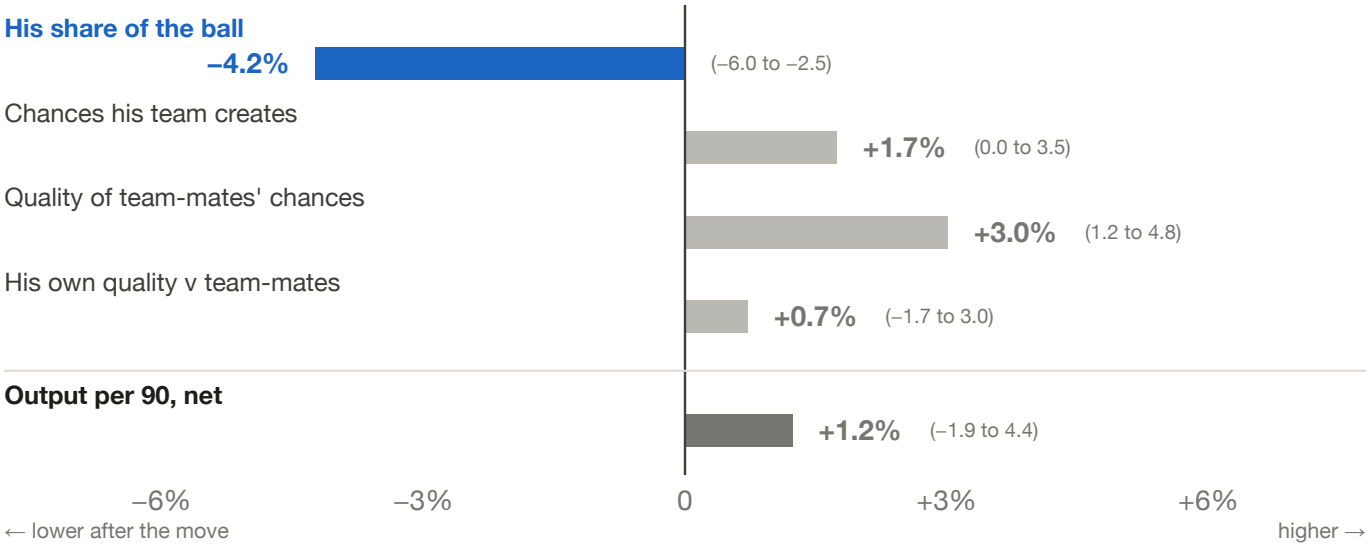
Against stayers with the same last season, a move cuts an attacker's share of his team's shots and shot-assists by –4.2% (–6.0% to –2.5%) (Opta –6.4%), and output per 90 barely moves (+1.2%; Opta –0.7%). The larger cost is his place: 44% of movers flop or drop below 900 league minutes, against 33% of stayers (+11.8 points (+8.0 to +15.4) matched; Opta +14.0). Regulars who keep their place flop about as often as luck predicts on Understat, less clearly on Opta.

–4.2%
share of the ball after a move, matched

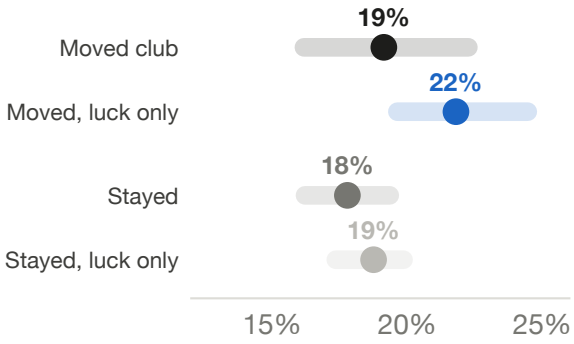
+11.8 pts
flop or lost his place, movers v stayers

+0.5%
pair chemistry, second season v first (–0.2 to 1.2)

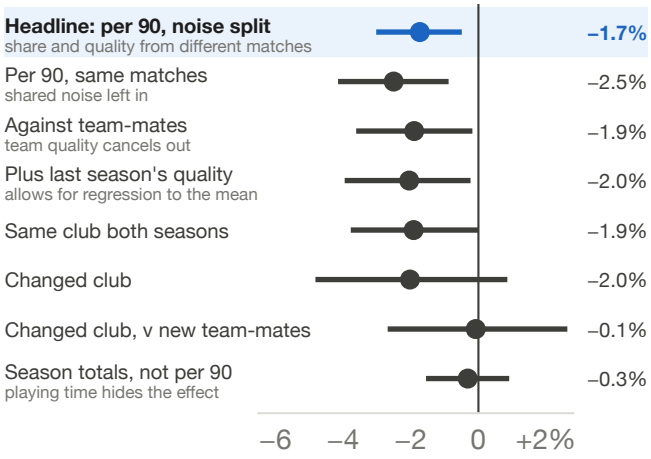
What a move does, against stayers with the same last season (per 90)



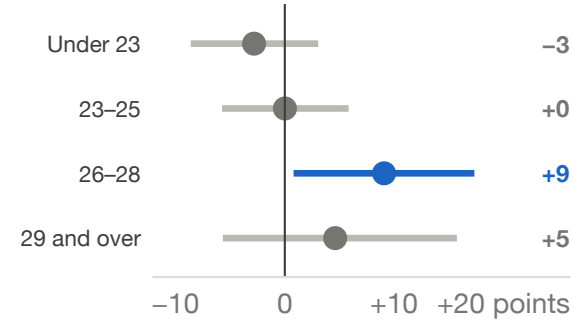
Flop rates against luck alone



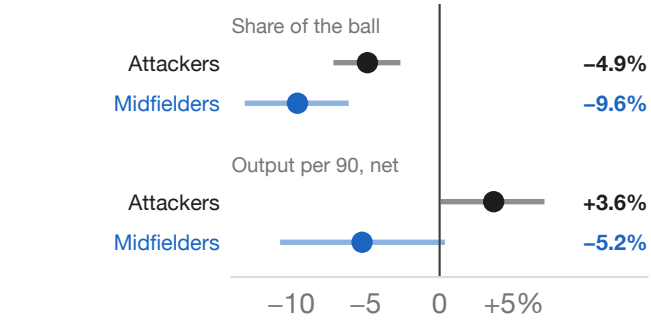
Same player, 5 points more of the ball



Flop rate by age, moved minus stayed (points)



After a move: attackers v midfielders (raw)



Limits: observational and exploratory, nothing pre-registered; shots and shot-assists only; the four-part split is accounting; no betting, fantasy or prop market tested, so no trading signal. Big-5: top divisions of England, Spain, Italy, Germany, France.
Data: Understat, Opta via FBref, Transfermarkt. 95% intervals.

github.com/benedictprimmer-web/football-usage-efficiency